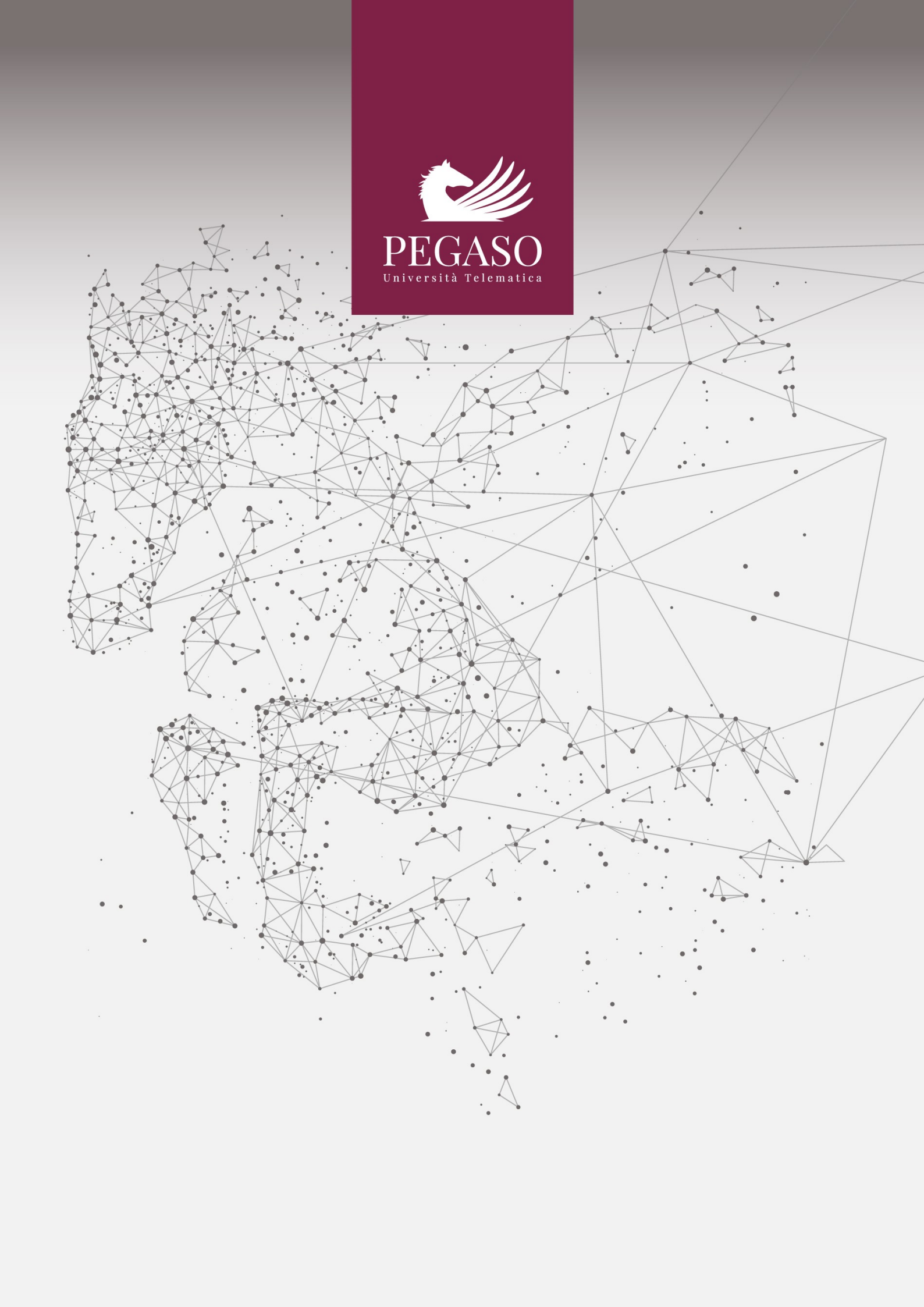

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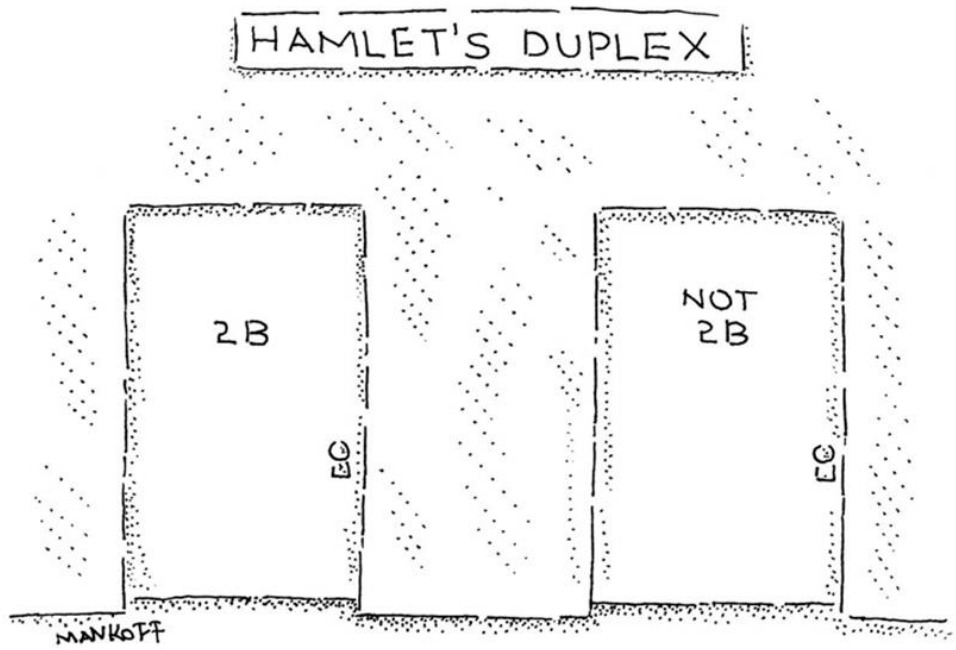
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1. Introduction to the verb be



THE NEW YORKER COLLECTION/THE CARTOON BANK

BE is a verb of great importance in the English language. It is used as a main verb and as an auxiliary verb. It is used in the passive as well.

BE is the only English verb that has three conjugations in the present simple (**am** | **are** | **is**). All other verbs have just two conjugations.

BE is also the only verb that has two conjugations in the past simple (**was** / **were**). All other verbs have only one past tense conjugation.

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Here are the conjugations for BE in the present simple.

	singular			**plural**	
1st person	I	am		we	are
2nd person	you	are		you	are
3rd person	he, she, it	is		they	are

Here are conjugations for the verb BE in the past simple.

	singular			**plural**	
1st person	I	was		we	were
2nd person	you	were		you	were
3rd person	he, she, it	was		they	were

The verb BE, when proceeded by an adjective, is used to describe a person, place, or thing.

Person		**Place**		**Thing**
I am happy.		Italy is warm.		The skyscraper is tall.
She is great.		The rooms are spacious.		My ideas are good.
We were punctual.		Rome was beautiful.		The tea was hot.

The verb BE can be followed by a noun to identify a person or a relationship.

I am a student.
He is a teacher.
We are classmates.

BE can be followed by a preposition to identify the location of a person or thing.

Person	I am at home.
	The man is in the office.
Thing	The keys are by the table.
	My book was on the shelf.

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The verb BE is used to describe age, height, length, weight, size, shape and color.

It is used to describe physical conditions.

She is my age.
The road is long.
I'm cold.

BE is used to talk about the time and the weather.

What time is it?		It is 2:30pm.
When was the party?		It was at 7pm.
How is the weather?		It is rainy.
How was Finland?		It was hot.

Question Formation with BE

We create questions with the verb BE by inverting the order of the verb BE and the subject.

		Inversion of Subject/Verb	**QUESTION**
He is bored.		Is he…	Is he bored?
I am talking loudly.		Am I…	Am I talking loudly?
It was raining.		Was it…	Was it raining?
They were sold out.		Were they…	Were they sold out?

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BE can be used with other verbs to create different verb forms and tenses.

BE + present participle	I am eating.	Present Continuous
	He was working.	Past Continuous
BE + past participle	Art is shown here.	Passive Present
	The bread was eaten.	Passive Past
BE + infinitive	I am to leave tomorrow.	Future Form
	She was to call for me.	Future in Past

The past participle of the verb BE is **been**. This form is used in perfect tenses.

I have been at home two hours.	Present Perfect Simple
The dog has been sleeping all night	Present Perfect Continuous
They had been to London six times.	Past Perfect Simple
I had been sleeping for hours.	Past Perfect Continuous

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2. Contractions with BE

The verb BE is often contracted with subject pronouns or the adverb of negation **not**.

uncontracted	words joined	first letter eliminated	**contracted**
I am	Iam	I~~a~~m	I'm
You are	Youare	You~~a~~re	You're
She is	Sheis	She~~i~~s	She's

For example:

uncontracted	**contracted**
I am sad.	I'm sad.
You are terrible.	You're terrible.
She is young.	She's young.
We are angry.	We're angry.
They are good.	They're good.

The present simple of the verb BE is frequently contracted with the adverb of negation **not**. A conjugated form of the verb BE is joined to **not** and the **o** in **not** is replaced with an apostrophe.

uncontracted	words joined	letter **o** eliminated	**contracted**
is not	isnot	isn~~o~~t	isn't
are not	arenot	aren~~o~~t	aren't

Example sentences:

uncontracted	**contracted**
The cat is not friendly.	The cat isn't friendly.
They are not at work.	They aren't at work.

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It is not possible to contract the simple present of the first person singular form of BE (**am**) and the adverb of negation **not**.

uncontracted		**contracted**
I am not happy.		~~I amn't happy.~~

Note that the verb BE can be contracted with a subject or the adverb of negation **not**. There is no difference in meaning between these sentences.

uncontracted		**with subject**	**with "not"**
I am not late.		I'm not late.	—
You are not happy.		You're not happy.	You aren't happy.
She is not wealthy.		She's not wealthy.	She isn't wealthy.
We are not at home.		We're not at home.	We aren't at home.
They are not so old.		They're not so old.	They aren't so old.

The past simple of the verb BE (**was** / **were**) cannot be contracted with a subject in the affirmative.

uncontracted		**contracted**
I was at the store.		xxx
You were here.		xxx
She was tall.		xxx
They were sleeping.		xxx

However, the simple past of BE can contract with the adverb of negation **not**.

uncontracted		**contracted**
I was not home.		I wasn't home.
You were not here.		You weren't here.
She was not tired.		She wasn't tired.
They were not drinking.		They weren't drinking.

In spoken English, contractions are formed with any noun followed by the third person form of BE (**is**). This is considered **informal** speech.

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uncontracted		**contracted**
Their dog is small.		Their dog's small.
The building is new.		The building's new.
My idea is not bad.		My idea's not bad.

Contractions with BE are not possible with a subject when BE is the final word of a sentence (for example, in response to a question).

question		**response**		**incorrect**
Who is going?		I am.		~~I'm.~~
Is it noon?		Yes, it is		~~Yes, it's.~~
Are they here?		Yes, they are.		~~Yes, they're.~~

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3. Formulations with BE

We often use **There** with BE and **It** with BE as a subject but they do not refer to any particular object.

There is/was and **There are/were** are used to introduce a topic or say that something exists.

* There is so much going on today
* Is there anything playing at the cinema?
* There are a few good players on the team.
* Are there any new students in the class?

It is/was often used for the weather, time and distance

* It is cold and rainy today.
* It is nine o'clock.
* It is two miles away.
* It is Sunday tomorrow.
* Is it a long way to walk?
* It was cold and rainy yesterday.
* It was nine o'clock when it rained.
* It was two miles away.
* It was Sunday yesterday.
* Was it a long way to walk?

It + BE + adjective + infinitive clause refers forward to the infinitive clause

* It is nice to meet you.
* It is hard to hear in here.
* Is it hard to understand him?
* It will be difficult to get there without a map.
* It was nice to meet you.

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* It was hard to hear there.
* Was it hard to understand him?
* It would be difficult to get there without a map.

BE is used in the formulation of the passive - we use the passive when we talk about an action but are not so interested in who or what does / did the action. We use the preposition **By** to introduce the agent of the action.

Subject + BE + past participle is the formula for the passive

Active		**Passive**		**Tense**
I make bread		Bread is made		Present Simple
I am making bread		Bread is being made		Present Continuous
I have made bread		Bread has been made		Present Perfect

It is said that + clause..., Subject + is thought to + infinitive...

These are formal structures used especially in news reports with the verbs know, tell, understand, report, expect, say, believe, and think. It makes the information sound more impersonal.

1. We use It is said, believed, etc. + that + clause.
2. We use He, The man, etc. (i.e. the subject of the clause) + is said, believed, etc. + to + infinitive (e.g. to be) or perfect infinitive (e.g. to have been) when talking about the past.

They say that the fire was started deliberately. (Active)
It is said that the fire was started deliberately. (Passive)

People think that the mayor will resign. (Active)
It is thought that the mayor will resign. (Passive)

People say the man is in his 40s. (Active)

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The man is said to be in his 40s. (Passive)

The police believe he has left the country. (Active)

He is believed to have left the country. (Passive)

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4. Useful Phrases and Collocations with BE

Be allowed to + infinitive

They are allowed to research any subject they would like.

Be about to + infinitive

The government is about to announce a new initiative.

Be due to + infinitive

The plane is due to arrive any minute.

Be supposed to + infinitive

The company is supposed to announce its plans to its shareholders within the month.

Be meant to + infinitive

The summary was meant to be useful to you.

Be likely to + infinitive

The meeting is likely to last longer than expected.

Be able to + infinitive

He was able to prove his theory through his research.

Be going to + infinitive (future)

In the meeting this afternoon we are going to explain how we came to this conclusion.

Be accused of + gerund / noun

They were accused of deceiving the investors.

Be affected by + gerund / noun

The ticket sales were affected by the weather conditions.

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Be aware of + gerund / noun

I am aware of the problem.

Be attached to + gerund / noun

We are attached to our pets.

Be bad at + gerund / noun

She is bad at remembering names.

Be bad for + gerund / noun

Smoking is bad for you.

Be bored with + gerund / noun

The audience was bored with the wait.

Be capable of + gerund / noun

They are perfectly capable of helping you out.

Be clear about + gerund / noun

I want to be clear about what I expect.

Be compared to + gerund / noun

It is often compared to other companies of its kind.

Be dedicated to + gerund / noun

We are dedicated to serving our clients well.

Be embarrassed about + gerund / noun

She is embarrassed about having misunderstood your question.

Be encouraged by + gerund / noun

I am encouraged by the effort my students are making.

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Be faced with + gerund / noun

The management is often faced with a lot of criticism.

Be good at + gerund / noun

We are good at making people feel comfortable.

Be grateful for + gerund / noun

She is grateful for the time off.

Be guilty of + gerund / noun

He is guilty of failure to complete his tasks on time.

Be impressed with + gerund / noun

The boss is impressed with the progress we've made.

Be interested in + gerund / noun

We are interested in the job.

Be knowledgeable about + gerund / noun

This company is knowledgeable about the current trends.

Be suspected of + gerund / noun

I am suspected of fraud.

EXERCISES

Make questions with these words.

1. (is / at home / your mother) ex. Is your mother at home?
2. (your parents / are / well) ex. Are your parents well?
3. (interesting / is / your job)
4. (the shops / are / open today)
5. (from / where / you / are)
6. (interested in sport / you / are)

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7. (is / near here / the post office)
8. (at school / are / your children)
9. (you / are / late / why)

Write the contracted form (she's / we aren't etc.).

10. she is ex.she's
11. they are
12. it is not
13. I am not
14. they are.
15. that is
16. you are not

Write am, is or are.

17. The weather _____ nice today.
18. I _____not rich.
19. This bag _____heavy.
20. These bags ___heavy.
21. Look! There ___Carol.
22. My brother and I_____ good tennis players.
23. Emily ____at home. Her children _____ at school.
24. My sister_____ a nurse.

Complete the sentences.

25. ex. Steve is ill. He's in bed.
26. I'm not hungry, but ____thirsty.
27. Mr Thomas is a very old man_____98.
28. These chairs aren't beautiful, but_____comfortable.
29. The weather is nice today. _____warm and sunny.
30. These bags____ heavy.

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Rewrite the sentences with the passive. Only use by if necessary.

31. People don't use this room very often.

ex. This room isn't used very often.

32. They subtitle a lot of foreign films.

A lot of foreign films_____.

33. García Márquez wrote Love in the Time of Cholera

Love in the Time of Cholera_____.

34. Someone is repairing my laptop.

My laptop_____.

35. They haven't released the DVD of the film yet.

The DVD of the film_____.

36. They won't finish the film until the spring.

The film_____.

37. You have to collect the tickets from the box office.

The tickets_____.

38. They hadn't told the actor about the changes in the script.

The actor_____.

39. James Cameron directed Avatar.

Avatar_____.

40. People like sitcoms.

Sitcoms_____.

Rephrase the sentence to make it more formal.

41. People think the murderer is a woman.

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ex. It is thought that the murderer is a woman.

42. Police believe the burglar is a local man.

The burglar_____.

43. People say the muggers are very dangerous.

It_____.

44. Police think the robbers entered through an open window.

The robbers_____.

45. Police say the murderer has disappeared.

It_____.

Complete the United Nations' definition of climate change with the verb BE in the correct form.

Climate change refers to long-term shifts in temperatures and weather patterns. Such shifts can (46.)____natural, due to changes in the sun's activity or large volcanic eruptions. But since the 1800s, human activities (47.)_____the main driver of climate change, primarily due to the burning of fossil fuels like coal, oil and gas.

Burning fossil fuels generates greenhouse gas emissions that act like a blanket wrapped around the Earth, trapping the sun's heat and raising temperatures.

The main greenhouse gases that (48.)_____causing climate change include carbon dioxide and methane. These come from using gasoline for driving a car or coal for heating a building, for example. Clearing land and cutting down forests can also release carbon dioxide. Agriculture, oil and gas operations (49.)___major sources of methane emissions. Energy, industry, transport, buildings, agriculture and land use (50.)_____among the main sectors causing greenhouse gases.

Climate scientists have showed that humans are responsible for virtually all global heating over the last 200 years. Human activities like the ones mentioned above are causing greenhouse gases that are warming the world faster than at any time in at least the last two thousand years.

The average temperature of the Earth's surface (51.)____now about 1.2°C warmer than it was in the late 1800s (before the industrial revolution) and warmer than at any time in the last 100,000 years. The

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last decade (2011-2020) (52.)_____the warmest on record, and each of the last four decades (53.)_____warmer than any previous decade since 1850.

Many people think climate change mainly means warmer temperatures. But temperature rise is only the beginning of the story. Because the Earth (54.)___a system, where everything (55.)____connected, changes in one area can influence changes in all others.

The consequences of climate change now include, among others, intense droughts, water scarcity, severe fires, rising sea levels, flooding, melting polar ice, catastrophic storms and declining biodiversity.

Translate the indicated sentences into Italian.

Climate change can affect our health, ability to grow food, housing, safety and work. (56.)Some of us are already more vulnerable to climate impacts, such as people living in small island nations and other developing countries. Conditions like sea-level rise and saltwater intrusion have advanced to the point where whole communities have had to relocate, and protracted droughts are putting people at risk of famine. In the future, the number of people displaced by weather-related events is expected to rise.

EXERCISE ANSWER KEY

1. Is your mother at home?
2. Are your parents well?
3. Is your job interesting?
4. Are the shops open today?
5. Where are you from?
6. Are you interested in sport?
7. Is the post office near here?
8. Are your children at school?
9. Why are you late?
10. she's
11. they're
12. it's not
13. I'm not

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14. they’re
15. that’s
16. you’re not / you aren’t
17. is
18. am
19. is
20. are
21. is
22. are
23. is … are
24. is
25. he’s in bed
26. I’m thirsty.
27. He’s 98.
28. They are comfortable.
29. It is warm and sunny.
30. These bags are heavy.
31. This room isn’t used very often.
32. A lot of foreign films are subtitled.
33. Love in the time of Cholera was written by Garcia Marquez.
34. My laptop is being repaired.
35. The DVD of the film hasn’t been released yet.
36. The film won’t be finished until the spring.
37. The tickets have to be collected from the box office.
38. The actor hasn’t been told about the changes in the script.
39. Avatar was directed by James Cameron.
40. Sitcoms are liked by people.
41. It is thought that the murderer is a woman.
42. The burglar is believed to be a local man.
43. It is said that muggers are very dangerous.
44. The robbers are thought to have entered through an open window.
45. It is said that the murderer has disappeared.

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46. be

47. have been

48. are

49. are

50. are

51. is

52. was

53. has been

54. is

55. is

56. Alcuni di noi, come le persone che vivono nelle piccole nazioni insulari e in altri Paesi in via di sviluppo, sono già più esposti agli impatti climatici. Condizioni come l'innalzamento del livello del mare e l'intrusione di acqua salata sono progredite al punto da costringere intere comunità a trasferirsi, e le siccità prolungate stanno mettendo le persone a rischio di carestia. In futuro si prevede un aumento del numero di persone sfollate a causa di eventi meteorologici.

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